

Comments in reST are as follows:

```
.. This is a comment
..
    _so: is this!
..
    [and] this!
..
    this:: too!
..
    |even| this:: !
```

reST directives

Directives are an extension mechanism for reStructuredText, a way of adding support for new constructs without adding new primary syntax.

Directives begin with an explicit Markup start (two periods and a space), followed by the directive type and two colons (collectively, the ‘directive marker’). The directive block begins immediately after the directive marker, and includes all subsequent indented lines. The directive block is divided into arguments, options (a field list), and content (in that order), any of which may appear.

As an example, consider the code-block syntax. It allows you to insert code (here, HTML) within your document:

```
.. code-block:: html
<h1>code block example</h1>
```

Similarly, using directives we can create a table by using CSV-like syntax. Here is an example:

```
.. csv-table:: a title
   :header: "name", "firstname", "age"
   :widths: 20, 20, 10

   "Smith", "John", 40

   "Smith", "John, Junior", 20
```

This is rendered as follows:

A title

name	firstname	age
Smith	John	40
Smith	John, Junior	20

Images can be included in a reST file, for example, as follows:

```
.. image:: picture.jpeg
   :height: 100px
   :width: 200 px
   :scale: 50 %
   :alt: alternate text
   :align: right
```

Images are a common use for substitution references as in the example shown below:

```
* |Red light| means stop.
* |Green light| means go.
* |Yellow light| means go really fast.
.. |Red light| image:: red_light.png
.. |Green light| image:: green_light.png
.. |Yellow light| image:: yellow_light.png
```

A ‘figure’ consists of image data (including image options), an optional caption (a single paragraph), and an optional legend (arbitrary body elements). For page-based output media, figures might float to a different position if this helps the page layout.

```
.. figure:: picture.png
   :scale: 50 %
   :alt: alternet text here
```

This is the caption of the figure (a simple paragraph).

This portion consists of all elements after the caption.

The ‘topic’ directive is used to

create a topic element, as follows:

```
.. topic:: Title

Body
```

The ‘contents’ directive generates a table of contents (TOC) in a topic. Topics, and therefore tables of contents, may occur anywhere a section or a transition may occur. Body elements and topics may not contain tables of contents.

Here's the directive in its simplest form:

```
.. contents::
```

An explicit title may be specified with the syntax:

```
.. contents:: Table of Contents
```

The most commonly used option for the contents directive is ‘depth’ – the number of section levels that are collected in the table of contents. The default is unlimited depth. The syntax is as follows:

```
.. contents:: Table of Contents
   :depth: 2
```

There is a lot that can be done with reST. I will be looking into support for different editors as well as tools like Pandoc, Sphinx and ReadTheDocs that assist in conversion, building, versioning and hosting the documents in my next article on this topic. 

References

- [1] <https://www.gnu.org/software/emacs/> "Emacs"
- [2] <https://www.vim.org/> "Vi Improved Editor"
- [3] <https://typora.io/> "Markdown Live Previewer"

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